

# Glossary

## Project Management

### Terms and Definitions

#### Course 4

---



## A

**Abandoned project:** A project in which inadequate handoff or transition on the project deliverables occurs

**Acceptance criteria:** Pre-established standards or requirements that a product, service, or process must meet

**Accessible:** Something that is easily used, accessed, or adapted for use by people experiencing disabilities

**Action item:** A task that needs to be completed

**Adoption metrics:** Metrics that indicate whether or not a product, service, or process is accepted and used

**Air cover:** Support for and protection of a team in the face of out-of-scope requests or criticism from leadership

**Analytics:** The process of answering business questions, discovering relationships, and predicting outcomes based on the analysis of data

## B

**Bad compromise:** A situation that occurs when two parties settle on a so-called solution but the end product still suffers

**Bar chart:** A type of chart that uses color and length to compare categories in a data set; useful for comparing values

**Bug:** A technical issue

**Burndown chart:** A line chart that measures the time against the amount of work done and the amount of work remaining; useful for projects that require a granular, broken-down look at each task

## C

**Change:** Anything that alters or impacts the tasks, structures, or processes within a project

**Change log:** A record of all notable changes on a project

**Character:** The qualities or features that make up and distinguish a person, like honesty, integrity, and kindness

**Collaboration:** People working together on an activity

**Confirmation bias:** A type of data bias that refers to the tendency to search for information that confirms preexisting beliefs

**Conger's four steps:** Refers to Jay A. Conger's four-step approach to effectively persuade and influence another person to consider new ideas: establish credibility, frame for common ground, provide evidence, and connect emotionally

**Continuous improvement:** An ongoing effort to improve products or services; begins with recognizing when processes and tasks need to be created, eliminated, or improved

**Control:** An experiment or observation designed to minimize the effects of variables

**Cost variance:** The difference between actual cost and budgeted cost

**Critical user journey:** The sequence of steps a user follows to accomplish tasks in a product

**Customer satisfaction score:** A metric that indicates how well the project delivered what it set out to do and how well it satisfies customer and stakeholder needs

# D

**Dashboard:** A type of user interface—typically a graph or summary chart— that provides a snapshot view of a project’s progress or performance

**Data:** A collection of facts or information; the numbers and feedback available about different aspects of a project

**Data analysis:** The collection, transformation, and organization of data to draw conclusions, make predictions, and drive informed decision-making

**Data bias:** A type of error that is influenced by one’s inherent beliefs

**Data ethics:** The well-founded standards of right and wrong that dictate how data is collected, shared, and used

**Data privacy:** The act of protecting a data subject’s information and activity any time a data transaction occurs

**Data visualization:** A graphical representation of information to facilitate understanding

**Data-driven improvement frameworks:** Techniques used to make decisions based on actual data

**Dependability:** A quality indicating team members are reliable and complete their work on time

**Dependencies:** Tasks, activities, or milestones that are reliant on one another

**Dependency management:** The process of managing interrelated tasks and resources within a project to ensure that the overall project is completed successfully, on time, and on budget

**Deviation:** Anything that alters the original course of action

**Discretionary dependencies:** Dependencies that could occur on their own, but the team saw a need to make those dependencies reliant on one another

**Diversity:** The set of differences each individual possesses, whether visible or invisible, that gives them a unique perspective on the world and their work

**DMAIC:** The five steps to take when working toward continuous improvements: define, measure, analyze, improve, and control

**Duration:** The amount of time it takes to complete or produce something

## E

**Edge case:** Rare outliers that the original requirements of the project didn't account for; deals with the extreme maximums and minimums of parameters

**Engagement metrics:** Metrics that indicate the degree to which a product or service is used—the frequency of use, amount of time spent using it, and the range of use

**Escalation:** The process of enlisting the help of higher-level project leadership or management to remove an obstacle, clarify or reinforce priorities, and validate next steps

**Ethical leadership:** A form of leadership that promotes and values honesty, justice, respect, community, and integrity

**Expressiveness:** Refers to one's ability to communicate with others

**External dependencies:** Asks that are reliant on outside factors, like regulatory agencies or other projects

## F

**Feedback survey:** A survey in which users provide feedback on features of a product that they like or dislike

**Force majeure:** An unforeseen circumstance that prevents someone from fulfilling a contract due to a major crisis

## G

**Gantt chart:** A project-tracking visual that is useful for staying on schedule; ideal for projects with many dependencies and larger project teams

## H

**Happiness metrics:** Metrics that relate to different aspects of the user's overall satisfaction with a product or service

**Headline:** The one-sentence main point that illustrates a slide

**History:** Refers to the level of personal history between oneself and another person

## I

**Impact:** The belief that the results of one's work matter and create change

**Impact report:** A presentation guided by a deck or slideshow that shows key stakeholders the value that's been added by the project

**Inclusive leadership:** A form of leadership where everyone's unique identity, background, and experiences are respected, valued, and integrated into how the team operates

**Inclusivity:** The practice or policy of including people who might otherwise be excluded or marginalized

**Influencing:** The ability to alter another person's thinking or behaviors

**Influencing statement:** A conversation opener that sets a person up for success with their audience

**Infographic:** A visual representation of information or data intended to present information quickly and clearly

**Information:** An organizational source of power that refers to one's level of access and control over information

**Internal dependencies:** The relationship between two tasks within the same project

**Interpretation bias:** A type of data bias that refers to the tendency to always interpret ambiguous situations as either negative or positive

**Issue:** A known and real problem that may affect the ability to complete a task

## K

**Knowledge:** Refers to the power drawn from one's expertise in certain subjects, unique abilities and skill sets, and ability to learn new things

**Key performance indicator (KPI):** A measurable value that demonstrates how effective a company is at achieving business objectives

## L

**Legend:** The bottom or side section of a chart that gives a small description of each section

**Line chart:** A type of chart that displays information as a series of data point markers; helpful for showing trends and behaviors over set periods of time or overall

## M

**Mandatory dependencies:** Tasks that are legally or contractually required

**Metric:** A quantifiable measurement that is used to track and assess a business objective

**Milestone:** An important point within the project schedule that indicates progress and usually signifies the completion of a deliverable or phase of the project

## N

**Network:** The people one is connected with professionally and personally

**Never-ending project:** A project in which the project deliverables and tasks cannot be completed



**Observer bias:** A type of data bias that refers to the tendency for different people to observe different things

**On-time completion rate:** A productivity metric that helps illustrate to clients and stakeholders how the project is progressing and when they can expect certain deliverables to be ready



**PDCA:** A four-step process that focuses on identifying a problem, fixing the issue, assessing whether the fix was successful, and fine-tuning the final fix; stands for: plan, do, check, and act

**Pie chart:** A type of chart divided into sections that each represent a portion of a whole; useful for making comparisons

**Portfolio:** A collection of programs and projects across a whole organization

**Probability and impact matrix:** A tool used to prioritize project risks

**Process improvement:** The practice of identifying, analyzing, and improving existing processes to enhance performance, meet best practices, or optimize consumer experiences

**Productivity metrics:** Metrics that track the effectiveness and efficiency of a project, including items like tasks, milestones, projections, and duration

**Program:** A collection of projects

**Project closeout report:** A document that describes what the team did, how they did it, and what they delivered; evaluates the quality of work and the project's performance with respect to budget and schedule

**Project closing:** A process performed to formally complete a project, the current phase, and contractual obligations

**Project status report:** An update that gives an overview of all of a project's common elements and summarizes them at a given point in time

**Project task:** An activity that needs to be accomplished within a set period of time

**Projection:** A prediction of a future outcome—such as future productivity trends, project durations, costs, performance, or quality—based on current information; also called a forecast

**Psychological safety:** An individual's perception of the consequences of taking an interpersonal risk



**Qualitative data:** Information about subjective qualities that can't be measured with numerical data

**Quality:** Refers to when the outlined requirements for the deliverable are fulfilled and meet or exceed the needs and expectations of customers

**Quality assurance:** A review process that evaluates whether a project is moving towards delivering a high-quality service or product; also called QA

**Quality control:** Techniques used to ensure quality standards when a problem is identified; also called QC

**Quality metrics:** Metrics that relate to achieving acceptable outcomes, such as number of changes, issues, and cost variance

**Quality planning:** The actions of the project manager or team to establish and conduct a process for identifying and determining exactly which standards of quality are relevant to the project as a whole and how to satisfy them

**Quality standards:** Requirements, specifications, or guidelines that can be used to ensure that materials, products, processes, and services are fit for achieving the desired outcome



**Quantitative data:** Statistical and numerical facts

## R

**RAG status report:** A report that follow a traffic light pattern to indicate progress and status: “red” indicates there are critical issues that need resolution, “amber/yellow” means that there are potential issues with schedule or budget, and “green” means the that the project is on track

**Reputation:** Refers to how others perceive a person overall

**Retrospective:** A meeting in which project teams discuss successes, failures, and possible future improvements on a project

**Risk:** A potential event that could occur and impact a project

**Risk exposure:** A way to measure potential future loss resulting from a specific activity or event

**Risk management:** The process of identifying, evaluating, and addressing potential risks and issues that could impact a project

**Risk register:** A table or chart that contains a list of risks

**Roadmap:** A project-tracking visual that is useful for high-level tracking of large milestones

**ROAM technique:** A strategy used to help manage actions after risks arise; stands for resolved, owned, accepted, and mitigated

**ROCCC:** An acronym used in data ethics best practices to ensure that data is reliable, original, comprehensive, current, and cited

**Role:** One’s position within an organization or team

## S

**Sampling bias:** A type of data bias in which the sample isn’t representative of the population as the whole

**Scope creep:** When changes, growth, and other factors affect a project’s scope

**Signal:** An observable change

**Signpost:** A way to clue the audience in to where a presentation is going and what to expect

**Stacked bar chart:** A type of bar chart that can show part-to-whole variables simultaneously; useful when comparing numerical information; also called a marimekko chart

**Storytelling:** The process of turning facts into narrative to communicate something to an audience

## T

**Team:** A group of people who plan work, solve problems, make decisions, and review progress in service of a specific project or objective

**Team dynamics:** The forces, both conscious and unconscious, that impact team behavior and performance

**Teamwork:** An effective, collaborative way of working in which each person is committed to and heading towards a shared goal

**Test case:** A sequence of steps and its expected results

**Timeboxing:** Refers to setting a time limit

**Timeout:** Refers to taking a moment away from the project to regroup and adjust the game plan

**Tracking:** A method of following the progress of project activities

**Trench wars:** Conflicts that occur when two peers or groups can't come to an agreement and neither party is willing to give in

## U

**User acceptance test:** A trial that helps a business make sure a product or solution works for its users; also called a UAT

**User story:** An informal, general explanation of a feature written from the perspective of the end user

## W

**Work groups:** People in an organization who work toward a common goal; based on and assigned by organizational or managerial hierarchy